WHAT IS LANGUAGE

Ferdinand de Saussure (1916)Language (langue) is a system of arbitrary signs shared by a speech community. Language is a structured system of signs.

Leonard Bloomfield (1933)"Language is the totality of utterances that can be made in a speech community.“ Language consists of observable speech behavior.

Edward Sapir (1921)"Language is a purely human and non-instinctive method of communicating ideas, emotions, and desires by means of voluntarily produced symbols.“ Language is a uniquely human symbolic communication system

Noam Chomsky (1957, 1965)"Language is a set (finite or infinite) of sentences, each finite in length and constructed out of a finite set of elements.“ Language is a rule-governed mental system capable of generating infinitely many sentences.

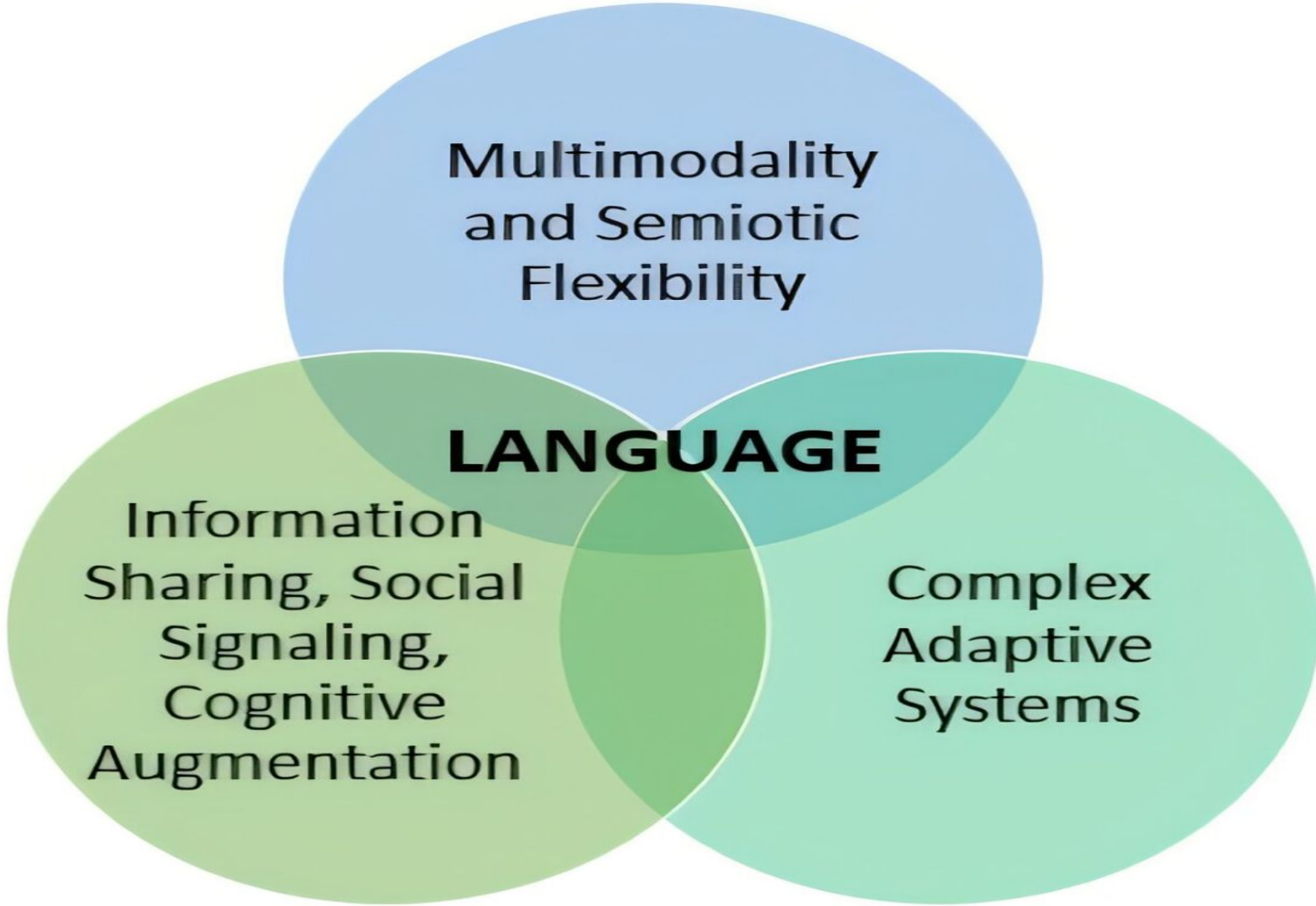
Charles F. Hockett (1958)Language is a communication system characterized by specific design features such as arbitrariness, displacement, and productivity. Human language has distinctive structural properties.

Benjamin Lee Whorf Language is not merely a tool for expressing thought but shapes how people perceive and conceptualize reality. Language influences cognition and worldview.

Lev VygotskyLanguage is the primary psychological tool for thought, learning, and cognitive development. Language and cognition develop together.

What is language; Language is not a spoken code. It's a dynamic, multimodal, socially embedded system that evolves through interaction, culture, and meaning-making.

A living, adaptive system that is shaped by how we use it, with whom, and in what context.


Multimodality and Semiotic Flexibility
LANGUAGE
Information Sharing, Social Signaling, Cognitive Augmentation
Complex Adaptive Systems

Multimodality and semiotic diversity: Rather than being limited to speech, languages are signed just as well as spoken. The use of gestures and facial expressions are an integral part of speech, not just "supplementary" add-ons. And more than language being a symbolic "arbitrary" code, we now know that iconicity—where sound or form resembles meaning (e.g., imitative gestures, onomatopoeias like "buzz," "crash," a slow drawl for "slooooow," and emoji in written communication)—is also essential to human communication. This multimodal and highly flexible nature is core to human language, allowing us to make just about any behavior into a communicative act.

Language as social and functional: Communication is not just about sending and receiving messages with a fixed code. It's about people creating shared meaning in context. A simple phrase like "Isn't that Tom's bike?" can mean "Let's meet here" or "Let's avoid this place"—depending on our history with Tom and with each other. Language also signals our identity, sometimes whether we like it or not (imagine, for example, always being identified as coming from a certain region or as being a non-native speaker just because of our accent). Language can thus promote closeness but also distance from each other. Language also has the power to shape our thought (such as when learning a new color term improves people's color discrimination).

Facial expression

Gesture and posture

Social functional

Social; identity, relationship; closeness, distance

Functional ; shape our thought, improve ides, evolve ideas

Language as an adaptive, evolving system: Many of language's most prominent features such as its productivity and compositional structure don't just "exist," but they arise in the process of social interaction and cultural transmission as the result of the cumulative interactions of many individuals over different timescales—from minutes to generations. Moreover, languages adapt to their social environment, with different community structures giving rise to the amazing cross-linguistic diversity we see today.

Language is not a static thing," adds senior author Dr. Limor Raviv from the Max Planck Institute for Psycholinguistics. "It's a dynamic, embodied, and deeply social act, which is flexible in form, function, and evolution. When we accept that, we see not just what makes us human—but how we are in fact connected to the wider story of animal communication."

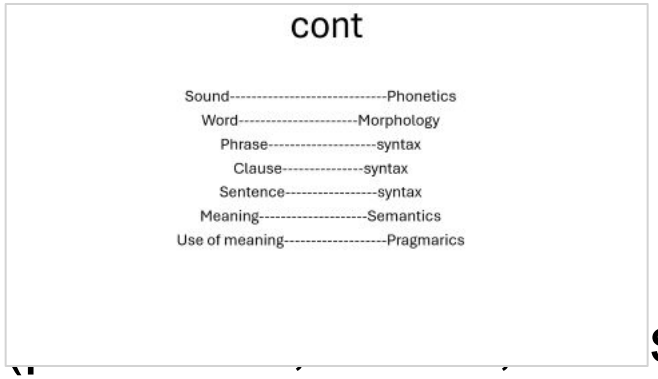
Design Features of language

Arbitrariness; the relation between word and its meaning is arbitrary and based on convention.

The word dog does not have any connection to the actual animal.

But there is a connection in other cases.

2.



Discreteness; language is composed of distinct units. (p se, sentence)

They can be combined in various ways to create meaning. These units are perceived categorically rather than continuously.

1.India won the match

cont

Sound----------Phonetics

Word----------Morphology

Phrase----------syntax

Clause----------syntax

Sentence----------syntax

Meaning----------Semantics

Use of meaning----------Pragmatics

3

Displacement ; Past, future event, abstract concepts and imaginary concepts

I was a student .

I will be playing cricket

Trust is source of relationship.

4,

Productivity ; Generation of an infinite number of new sentences and expressions from finite set of elements.

This allows for creativity and the ability to convey novel ideas.

Trust forms the basis of relationships.

Relationships grow out of trust.

Trust is the foundation of any relationship.

Duality; Operates on two levels; phoneme, morpheme, word, sentence

6.

Traditional Transmission; Not biologically inherent, learned socially through interaction with other speakers

Language is acquired from the surrounding environment.

7

Reflexiveness; language can be used to talk about language itself.

Aspect of language

8

Learnability; human can learn different languages

9.

Prevarication; human can use language to say things that are false, fictional or misleading